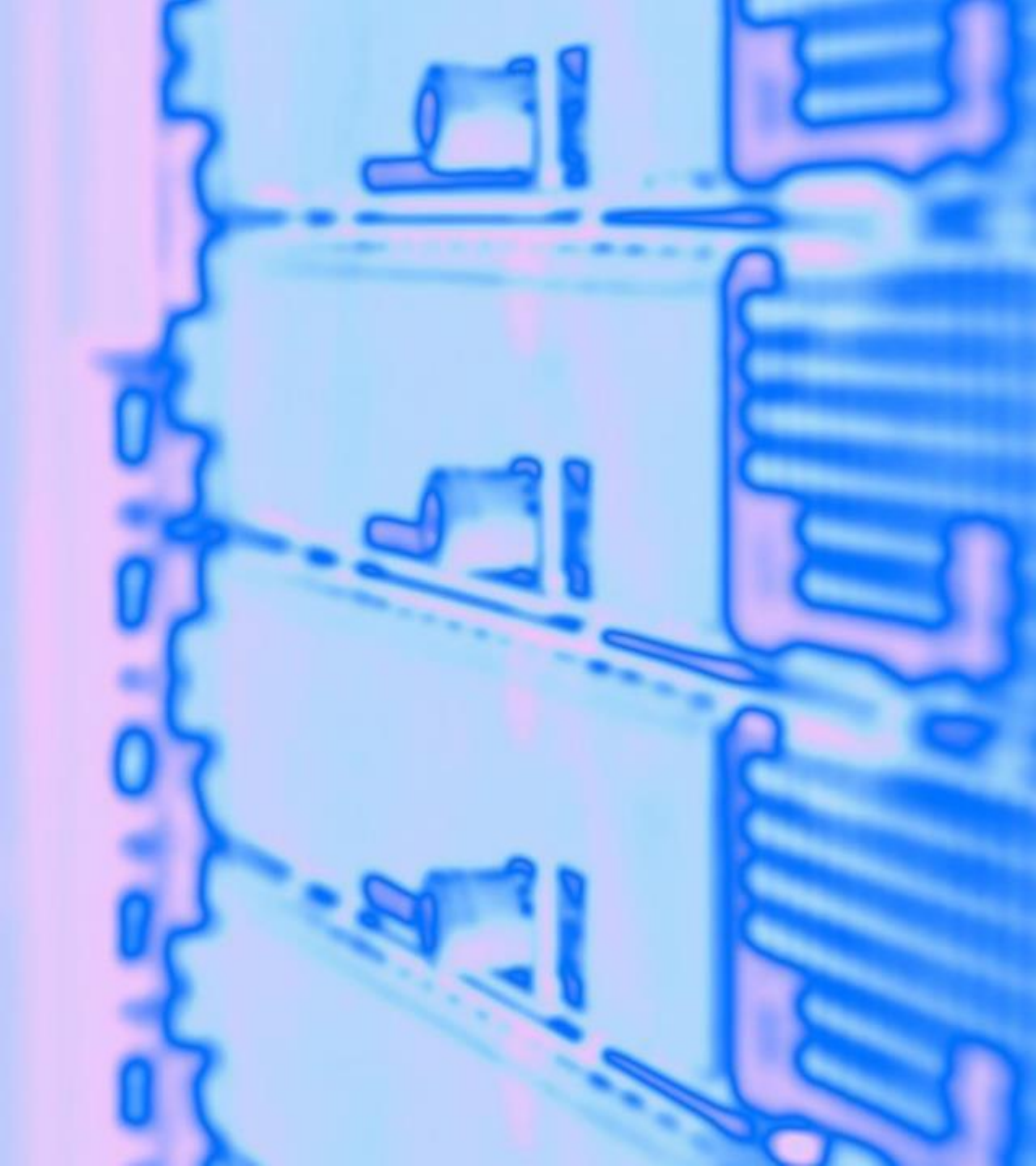
Deploy scalable ring-fenced Purview operations with Administrative Units



Defining ring-fenced operations with Admin Units

Many organizations have decentralized DLP operating model, requiring **independent, compliant, and scalable DLP operations**. These are frequently done with multiple DLP solutions and/or separate DLP instances.

When migrating to Purview, it's advantageous to execute a structured, multi-horizon plan to enable **scalable, ring-fenced DLP operations** and **consistent performance**. These are not just incremental improvements but reflect a scalable and assertive architecture for long term stabilization and scaling protection posture

Scalable Ring-Fenced Ops

- Shift to **Admin Unit–based decentralized governance** to enable **true business function autonomy** with strong separation (RBAC + data boundaries)
- Eliminate policy sprawl via **consolidation + retiring legacy**
- Phased rollout: **single entity** → **scale across business functions**

Performance Optimization

- **Reduce admin complexity** by deploying :
  - **Reusable lists** : Optimize management of frequently used lists across policies.
  - **Classifier health dashboard** : At-scale tracking of classifier health and performance
  - **Collection policies** : Reduce noise with scoped classifiers and activities for users
  - **Secure-by-default controls**: Targeted control of protection behavior in case of service or classification failure
- **Improve user experience** via Faster protection with Offline policy evaluation and JIT improvements

Administrative Units (AUs) overview

What are AUs in Microsoft Purview?
Allows partitioning your organization into smaller unit, such as operating company and/or business units, each with its own scoped administrators.

What are the partitioned capabilities?
An admin assigned to an AU can only manage users within that unit, such as DLP policies and visibility into their activities/alerts, and content explorer.

What type of functions remain within 'Global services'?
Tenant-wide configurations and settings, such as classification (sensitive info types), shared/global services. Tenant limits remain unchanged with the use of AUs.

Can we leverage both global and AU policies?
Absolutely, and recommended. For example, DLP policies applicable to multiple or all AUs should be defined globally. Users will be in scope of the sum of global+scoped policies. Scoped admins will have visibility of activities of users within their unit across all alerts.

Deploy scalable ring-fenced Purview operations with Administrative Units

Reference architecture

Layer 1: Central Governance (Global)

Global DLP Admin
Responsibilities:

- Define **baseline policies** across all users
- Maintain **global classifiers & reusable components**
- Central monitoring + reporting

Layer 2: Admin Units (Per business function)

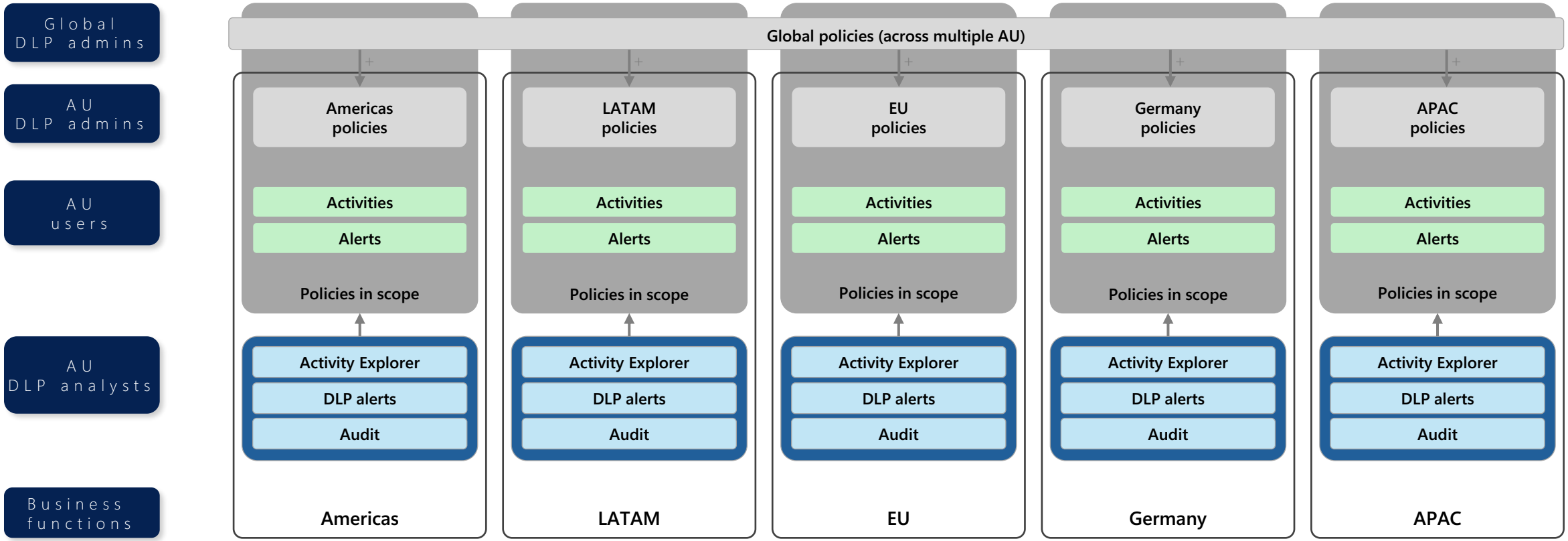
Global DLP Admin
Map each business function mapped to an **Admin Unit** with strict isolation

- Scoped RBAC
- Scoped policy visibility
- Scoped alert management

Layer 3: Business function-Level Operations

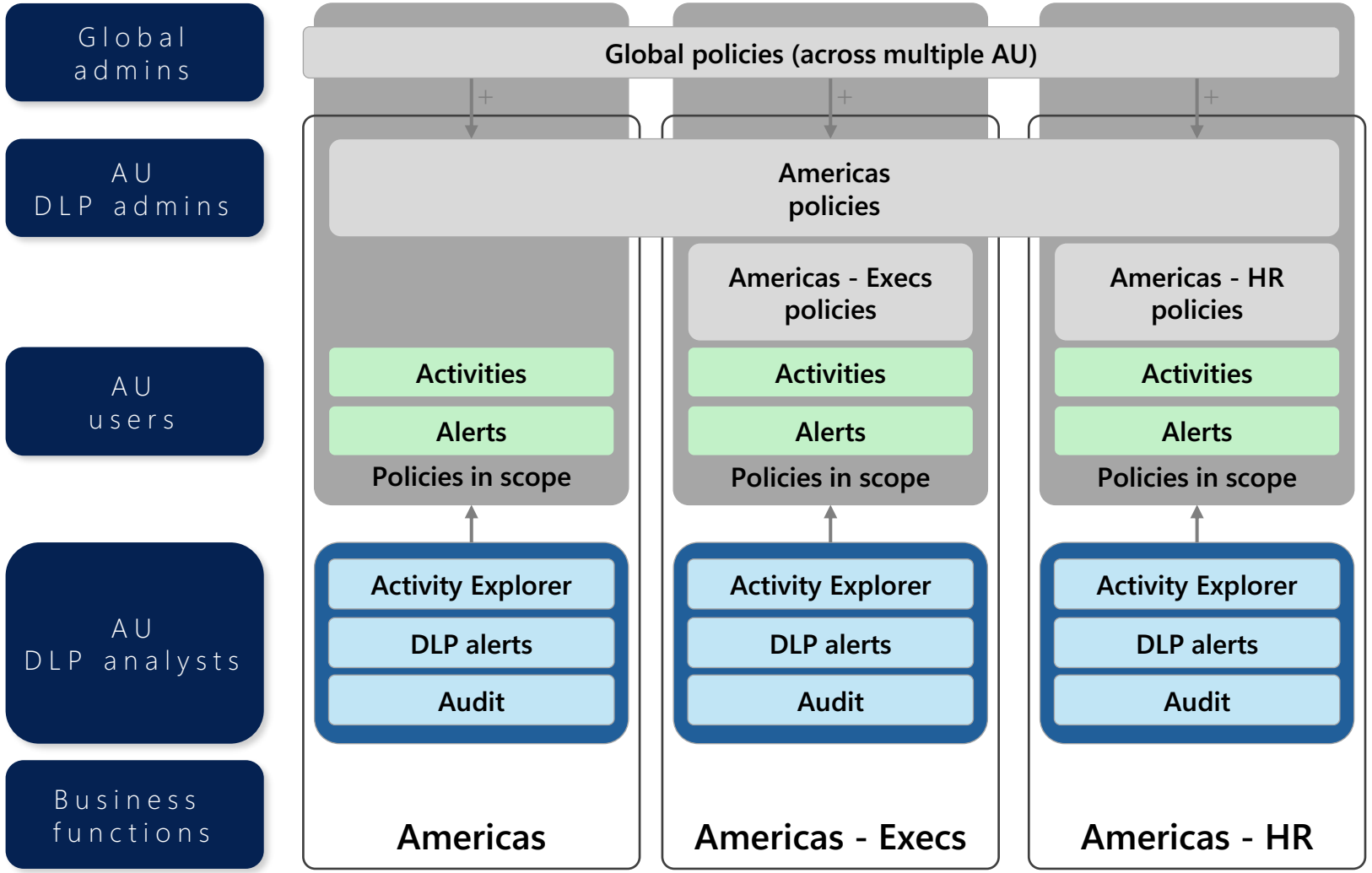
Scoped DLP admins

- Create/manage **local policies**
- Handle **alerts + incidents**
- Customize controls per regulatory needs



Ring-fencing user activity visibility to sub-business functions

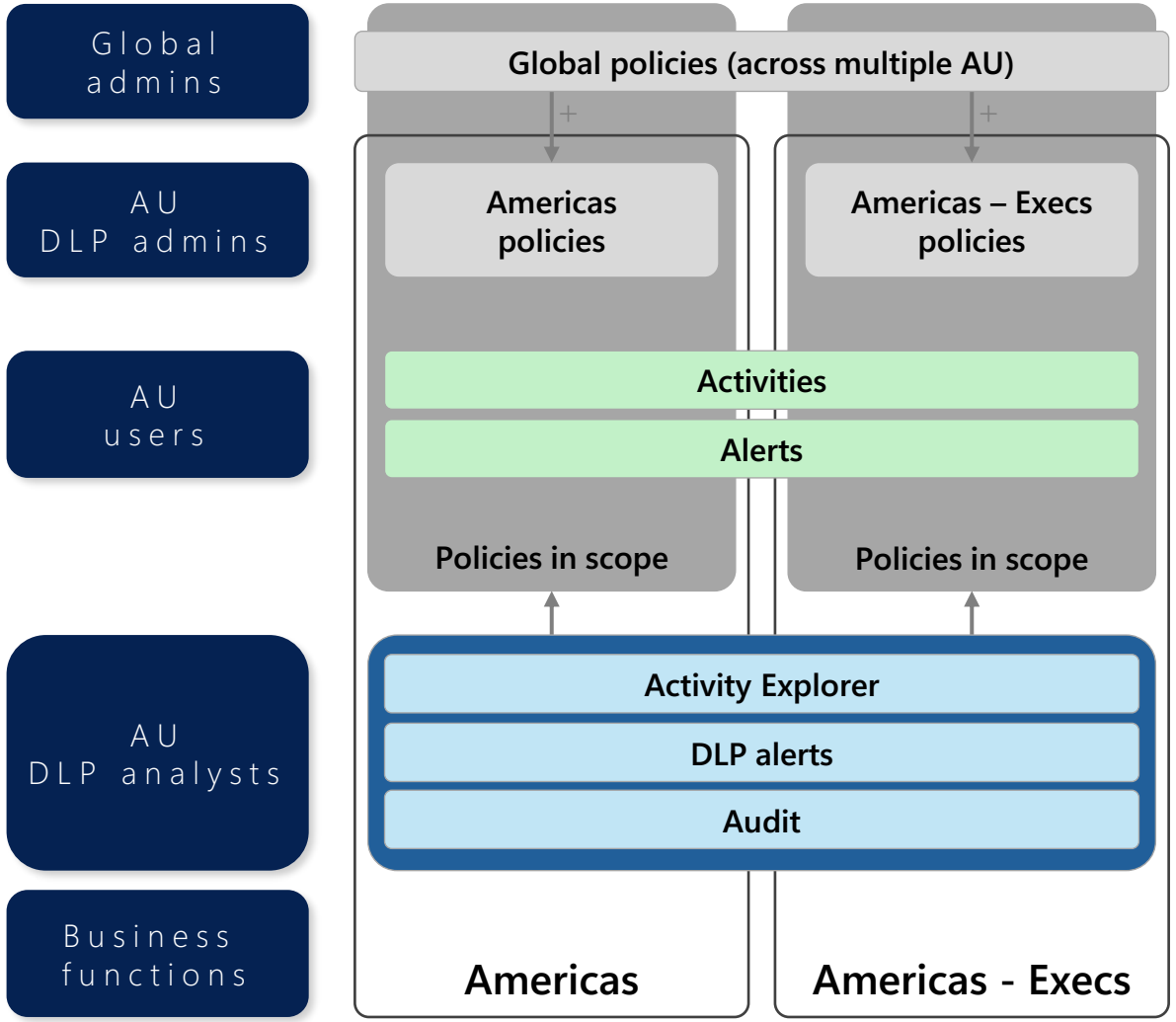
Reference architecture



- Scenario: "We have dedicated DLP analysts for executives. DLP alerts and activities for these users must only be available to that team"
- DLP Admins will require permissions on both AU, allowing the business function DLP admin to publish across multiple AUs.
- Users must be in a single AU to ensure only their respective DLP analysts can see their activities.

User activity visibility for multi-AU users

Reference architecture



- **User activities** are stamped with the sum of **all** AU they are in scoped of, at the time of the activity
- **Scoped DLP admins** can only create policies affecting users scoped in their AU
- **Scoped DLP analysts** will see **all** user activities for their scoped users, even if these activities are for policies scoped to a different AU

Separation of duties with Administrative Units (AU) in Microsoft Purview

	Global	Admin Unit
Communications Compliance (CC)	✓	✓+
Compliance Manager	✓	
Data Lifecycle Management (DLM)	✓	✓+
eDiscovery	✓	
Data Loss Prevention (DLP)		
Policies	✓	✓+
Settings	✓	
Information Protection (MIP)		
Label definition	✓	
Label publishing policies	✓	✓+
Sensitive Info Types (SIT) management	✓	
Collection policies	✓	✓+
Insider Risk Management (IRM)		
Policies	✓	✓+
Settings	✓	
Reviewing activities, audits and alerts		
Audit	*	✓*
Activity Explorer	*	✓*
DLP Alert (Purview and Defender)	*	✓*
Content/Data Explorer	*	✓*

✓+ Users will be in scope of both global and Admin Unit policies. Global policies can be configured for multiple AU / all users.

✓* AU analysts only see events (activities, audits, alerts) from their respective users.

* Reviewing events at global level for all users can be possible but should be an exception in most scenarios leveraging Administrative Units.